



REAL WORLD SOLUTIONS

The world has questions. We have answers.

April 24, 2025

Professor Michael Seaman
Department of Educational and Developmental Science
University of South Carolina
Columbia, SC 29208

Dear Professor Seaman:

I am writing regarding our contract with you and your analysts for data analysis to assist my company in answering our research questions. As I described in our recent phone conversation, RWS recently sent surveys to over 700 college seniors representing 23 major universities in the United States. These are all students who are preparing to graduate this spring. Each student agreed to participate in the study and signed a waiver allowing us to obtain data about a few demographic characteristics and their academic performance from their university records. They also agreed to complete a short (14-item) Likert-type survey. The purpose of the survey was to determine their optimism regarding their readiness and likelihood of obtaining a job after graduation that is consistent with their education and professional goals. Our research questions are these:

- Is senior-year grade point average (GPA) related to the degree of optimism about future employment?
- Is the relationship of GPA and optimism consistent or different for different categories of disciplines?
- Is the level of optimism different for different categories of disciplines?

I have put three Microsoft Excel data files on a secure company cloud-based file server. You can access these using the username and password that you registered with us last week. Here is a description of the files.

1. *Job Prep Demographics*

This file contains information on all students who consented to be in the study. We have assigned each participant a unique three-digit ID to protect student confidentiality. We have also assigned each university a school code, also to maintain their anonymity. For each student you will find their age and gender. This information has been categorized under five general categories: humanities (includes arts, history, philosophy, etc.), social sciences (includes anthropology, psychology, sociology, etc.), natural sciences (includes biology, chemistry, physics, etc.), formal sciences (includes mathematics, statistics, and computer science), and applied sciences (includes business, engineering, and medical disciplines).

2. *Job Prep GPA Data*

This file contains the same information as the job prep demographics file, excepting discipline category. It also contains the first and second semester GPAs of the students during their senior year, as well as how many credits they took each of these semesters. We thought that the average of the two semester GPAs might be the best measure to use as an indicator of academic performance when answering the first two research questions.

3. *Job Prep Survey Results*

This file includes the assigned ID followed by the responses on each of the 14 Likert items using a six-point scale. After accounting for reverse-scored items (items # 4, 9, 12, and 13), we use the sum as an indicator of optimism about future job prospects, with higher scores indicating greater optimism that after graduation the student will find a job that matches their educational attainment and expectations. Obviously not every student who consented to be in the study returned a survey, but we were quite pleased with the response rate of 72%.

Please let me know if you have any questions. We are excited about having the results from your analysts inform our work. I was very pleased to receive your reassurances that your current cohort of analysts are “highly-skilled and dedicated” to whatever tasks you give them, including this one. I’m certain the results will be evidence of the high regard you have for these individuals.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink that reads "Bob".

Robert. W. Habernooth
Vice President, Research Division